

is an event in which 32 women take part, and then An beats Wang in the final. The last 10 encounters between An and Wang, dating back to the start of 2025, have come in finals on the World Tour and at the Sudirman Cup, with the Korean winning every one of those matches.

The five wins she racked up in New Delhi have extended An's winning streak to 30 matches. More than the number of her wins, what is remarkable is that she has never seemed to have to get past third gear. The only emotion she showed at the Indira Gandhi Stadium came on championship point, when a powerful forehand smash forced Wang to block a return wide. That was when she punched her fist in the

air and let out a scream of triumph.

At no other moment did emotion seem to cross An's face.

It was not ruthless as much as it was relentless. After allowing Wang to close in to 13-15 following a couple of uncharacteristic errors, she went on an angry streak of winners, smashes to either side of the Chinese and drop shots in front of her, in retribution.

There was no respite for Wang even on the side of the court where the drift, which had bothered every other player in the tournament, was working in her favour by pushing the Korean's shuttles beyond where they normally would have flown. An made it look easy even though it was anything but.

Elite players learn to live with external conditions, but An has learned to go beyond them and even master them. Her opponent in the semifinals, Ratchanok, had marvelled at this ability.

"Even on the deep side, she could control every shuttle. I felt as if she was a step faster than me. I couldn't keep up with her," Ratchanok had said then.

While describing An, Ratchanok had a bemused look on her face, the kind one has when they are well and truly out of ideas on how to deal with a challenge.

In international badminton, few seem to be able to deal with her at all.

Speak to players who have



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